

COBBLING A NEW TEAM: Kumar with freshly sworn in ministers



NITISH'S POLL-VAULT

In his first reshuffle in over two years, the chief minister axes some ministers and brings in a few more but with the Lok Sabha elections just a year away, it may turn out to be too little too late

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar is a surprise package: a dour character bereft of any charisma, yet blessed with an ability to sell ice to an Eskimo, without any fear of retribution. That's precisely what he did on April 13 when after 28 months in office, he effected the first reshuffle of his cabinet. It showed the stamp of a man, humble on the outside, but determined not to brook any opposition to run his government the way he wants. Though Kumar was loathe to use the "sack"—he simply said they were being relieved of their duties to devote time for organisational work—10 ministers were shown the door, eight from his JD(U) and two from BJP while 19 new members were inducted into his cabinet.

Going by the average reshuffle cycle in many states, this was long overdue—Kumar took over the reins in November 2005 and opted to run the government with 27 ministers for more than 28 months. The government's dragging of feet on cabinet expansion had been a simmering source of anguish among JD(U) legislators, but Kumar had managed to keep it in check thanks to the streak of autocracy and diplomacy that concurrently runs in him. Earlier, it was assumed that he was purposefully putting the expansion on hold to avoid a rebellion in the NDA ranks as there was no shortage of claimants. But the reshuffle has opened up new wounds, treating which could take up a lot of his time in the coming months.

The timing of the reshuffle is equally important, because it comes

with not many months left for the Lok Sabha polls and for the axed ones—many of whom have been informally shown the prospects of a Lok Sabha ticket—a reason to stay useful. The composition of his new team, too, suggests that the expansion has been done as a preparatory measure for the Lok Sabha polls where the NDA is banking on Kumar to shore up its presence. He has, therefore, picked up the horses for the ensuing race. A caste balance is evident in the revamp, as those dropped have been replaced with members of the same caste. Similarly, the two Muslim ministers—Monazir Hassan and Manzar Alam—have been replaced by Shahid Ali Khan and Jamshed Ashraf, both from JD(U). Of the 19 new faces, seven are from coalition partner BJP and 12 from JD(U). The reshuffle has come close on the heels